



jQuery

jQuery has gained popularity over the years and is the most widely used JavaScript library. If you are still developing websites using basic HTML and JavaScript, it's time to switch to jQuery.

The jQuery JavaScript library makes coding easy for programmers. With many extensions and plug-ins, it is the choice of many programmers. "Write less, do more," is the jQuery motto, and it has lived up to this all these years. There are many other JavaScript libraries, but what makes jQuery special is its elegance, flexibility and powerful constructs.

Personally, learning jQuery was similar to learning Perl. At first glance, the cryptic syntax could make even simple code difficult to decipher. While authors and experts enjoy reducing the most complex pieces of code to just a few lines, reviewers and newbies might find it a nightmare. But if you stare at the examples for a few days, you can easily get enchanted with the magic of jQuery.

This article is not to demonstrate jQuery's great power and extensive functionality, but just to get you started without inhibitions. You should already have some basic knowledge of JavaScript, HTML and CSS.

Why use jQuery?

The most important reason, which is the same as for other libraries, is to avoid reinventing the wheel. The most common operations that website designers perform are readily available with code and tested for many browsers. Let us just learn what's available and use jQuery as a 'black box'.

The best part is the documentation, available at jquery.com. Most examples have demos associated and can be copied directly into an editor. The code is ready for production with just a few changes. For advanced users, who would like to create a custom look-and-feel, the jQuery website also has tools to play around with.

The first three inhibitors

\$ is all over

The most basic aspect of jQuery is the \$ (dollar sign), a shortcut for 'jQuery'. Replacing the \$ with 'jQuery' would yield better readability, but still, the \$ is used most commonly.

In-line anonymous functions

If you are used to just basic JavaScript, the second most often used coding style in jQuery is in-line anonymous functions. The most common example is the anonymous function used when the document is loaded in the browser. jQuery has a function called `ready()` that takes a function as its parameter. Though the conventional way is to first define a function and then pass the name as its reference (left code snippet in Table 1), in most jQuery code you will find extensive use of in-line anonymous functions (right code snippet in Table 1). With a number of callback or handler functions in jQuery, the in-line function usage is better for readability—also, anonymous functions do away with the need for 'creative' function names (like `foo()`, `myfunc()`, `myfunc2()`, etc)!

Table 1

<pre><script type="text/javascript"> function sample_func() { // function body goes here } \$(document.ready(sample_ func)); </script></pre>	<pre><script type="text/javascript"> \$(document). ready(function() { //function body goes here }); </script></pre>
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